

Images of the Desert — Ar'ar and Tamarisk

PRIMARY TEXTS: JEREMIAH 17, GENESIS 21

**Did you plant
any tamarisks
today?**

Did you plant any tamarisks today? When posed with this reflective question, I think of my grandmother. Watching her aging, chemo-stricken hands shake trying to hastily finish the quilt for my cousin's coming baby—grandma's first great-grandchild. She finally let my incompetent hands help her tie the small pieces of yarn in every other patch of the brightly colored quilt.

In the coming years, she fought the repeated health diagnosis with fierce tenacity, and her quilting shifted to knitting beautiful potholders, washcloths, and here and there a small blanket. She tried to teach me once, but this ended in laughter after showing her how my "potholder" was a more fitting slipper.

Then came the year my baby girl was born, and grandma was so near finishing the small knitted blanket, the sweet light rainbow colors of the yarn pulled and braided together with such love, discipline, and even pain. But she got sick, again, and the blanket, near completion, lay unfinished. So her dear friend walked down the street to her home and finished it for her, right by her side. Grandma passed away just two months after my daughter was born, leaving closets full of blankets, prayers braided into yarn, a garden of bleeding hearts (her favorite flower), and a life plotted with tamarisks.

That dear friend of grandma wrapped my sweet baby up in that blanket at the funeral and held her close. A lifetime of friendship and legacy of love and community and goodness weaved together for generations to come. I remember rocking my baby girl after the funeral. Holding her in that blanket, crying tears of grief and joy, and feeling something a little like hope, a little like peace, a little like a deep, full breath at long last. Perhaps it was that shade of the tamarisk, making the desert of loss and grief so much lighter and cooler in the shade of legacy.

**making the desert... so
much lighter and cooler in
the shade of legacy**

We can ask ourselves at the end of each day, how many tamarisks did I plant today? I believe this is a powerful practice. Yet, perhaps sometimes we are plantings seeds, or dropping them in loose soil at least, without consciously knowing it. If we have been actively creating space for God to fill—through our spiritual disciplines and efforts to not fill all the margins—we can't help but plant seed, possibly ones as deeply rooted as tamarisks, along the way.

Perhaps filling ourselves with more of God, His work, His creation, His Sabbath, His celebrations, His sacrifice—is what plants and continually waters the tamarisks we leave behind. As those who come after us dig to lay a new foundation, as they cry tears into what looks like dry, dying soil, or as they seek refuge and healing after the burn of fruit that appeared so beautiful at first glance, but left them empty in the end, they find shade.

It's not about what we look like as we seek to create space for a Kingdom of tamarisks, but it's also not about keeping track, or score, of them either.

It's about being open, weak, vulnerable, real. It's about being different from the inside out. It's about our lives being so rooted in goodness, community, radical hospitality, sacrifice, and freedom. It's about being a Kingdom of priests, taking on the cause of those we meet—whether it be finishing a baby blanket or holding another's arms up with your own when their strength begins to fail. Imagine a desert full of tamarisks. A community so full of the love of Christ, that trusts the Story, that there is no way to escape the shade of its branches—and no reason to want to.

**It's about being
different from the
inside out**

A Kingdom, a community, of tamarisks. Holding and healing our shaking, aging hands, wrapping each other's children in love, and knitting God into each and every moment of our lives. A legacy that moves beyond deserts and oceans and fertile lands, a legacy that began in the garden, and we can be partners in forever.

PRAYER

*Search my heart, God
The depths of my soul—my “very”
and may your light and love flourish within me.
I set my confidence in you.
My roots planted in your rich soil;
seeking the water and life I need
to withstand the heat, in dry and weary lands.
Rather than gaze at my own reflection,
may I look at those coming after me, the future before them.
And may I choose to plant seeds for
the Kingdom tamarisks of tomorrow.
May the lives of every alien, orphan, and widow,
every student, refugee, and image-bearer I meet
be made better because of your work within me.*

*Search my heart, Lord, and make it so.
Amen*

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 28

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What might be important to meditate over from the images present in Jeremiah 17 and Genesis 21? What part of the Genesis or Exodus stories may you want to just sit with?



COMMUNITY

How does your community seek to leave lasting Kingdom impact? How might you provide shade for one another and pass that along to those you meet?



DISCIPLESHIP

The image of the tamarisk has such a beautiful connection to discipleship. Who can you bring alongside you not just to bring shade to, but to bring teaching and hope into their life—and it may not come to any fruition you can see?



WRESTLING

What are you wrestling with? The contextual images of ar'ar and tamarisk? Our ideas of hidden growth? How the images fit in Jeremiah and Genesis? Remember, questions and wrestling are good! Especially in community.



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*We believe that **if we do our part in creating space for God, He will fill it.** What spiritual practices might you need to connect with God so that planting tamarisks can become a natural part of your life? How might the smallest practice fill you with more of Him and help you provide more long-lasting shade for others? What practice could you refine, pick up again, or challenge yourself to try for the first time? If you create the space—He will fill it.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe young adults are shaping the future, and they need to experience the shade of the Holy Spirit—and this can happen through people like you! **They need to see what it looks like to follow God in the wilderness, to trust the Story, not just looking for shade for themselves but ways to provide it for others who may walk these paths after them.** To impact the world. Let God do the heavy lifting, but be on the lookout for those young people to help them create tamarisks of their own.*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*Imagine how our world, our theology of work, might be different if we lived each moment not just trusting that God will provide shade, but that we will be shade for others. Leave the world, the desert, better than we found it. Living in intimacy with God is about how you put Him on display, in how you pursue your 9–5, and how that changes you, the people you meet, and those who come after you. Does your physical work put you in a position to be shade? To make lasting impact? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can make an impact. **You are doing sacred work and can be a tamarisk—no matter where you are.***